

4.7

Diplomatic language

Worksheet

- A** Practise speaking these pairs of sentences. Say the sentences on the left in a strong, direct way. Say the sentences on the right in a diplomatic way: speak more slowly, use pauses and start questions with a higher voice.

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| 1 Can I go back to the point about timing? | Could I <u>just</u> go back to the point about timing? |
| 2 It's <u>very hot</u> in here. | It's <u>a bit hot</u> in here, <u>isn't it</u> ? |
| 3 We have a problem. | It seems we have a slight problem. |
| 4 There'll be a delay. | There might be a small delay. |
| 5 Can I interrupt for a moment? | Could I just interrupt for a moment? |
| 6 That'll be very expensive | That might be quite expensive. |
| 7 That'll be very expensive. | Won't that be a bit expensive? |
| 8 Can we meet again next week? | Perhaps we could meet again next week? |

- What are the advantages and disadvantages of using direct language?
- In which business situations would you expect to hear diplomatic language?

- B** Complete the table below with the sentence numbers from section A. The first two sentence numbers have been done for you.

a can ➤ could	1	e seems/appears	
b will ➤ might		f negative question	2
c perhaps/maybe		g a small/a slight (+ noun)	
d just	1	h a bit/quite (+ adjective)	2

- C** Rewrite these phrases so that they are more diplomatic. Use techniques from section B and your own ideas. Practise speaking your new phrases.

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|--|-------|
| 1 I want to make a change to the agenda. | _____ |
| 2 It'll be better to ship the goods via Singapore. | _____ |
| 3 We have a problem with our assembly line. | _____ |
| 4 That will be difficult. | _____ |
| 5 Can I finish what I was saying? | _____ |
| 6 Your estimate for the total cost is too low. | _____ |
| 7 That's very strange. | _____ |
| 8 The project is running late. | _____ |

- D** One person in each situation below will use diplomatic language. Act out the situations with a partner.

- You are at the reception desk of a big company and want to see the President for a few minutes.
- You have to tell a customer that there will be a delay of 4 weeks with the goods.
- You are talking to a journalist who wants to write a story about your company's latest (bad) profit figures.
- You are talking to a customer who is complaining about the bad service of your company. Decide before you begin what the complaint is about.